Globalizations

ISSN: 1474-7731 (Print) 1474-774X (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rglo20

Renewable energy and EU-led authoritarian neoliberalization: small hydropower in Rakita, Serbia and the upscaling of environmental struggles

Aleksandra Piletić

To cite this article: Aleksandra Piletić (2024) Renewable energy and EU-led authoritarian neoliberalization: small hydropower in Rakita, Serbia and the upscaling of environmental struggles, Globalizations, 21:6, 1092-1107, DOI: 10.1080/14747731.2023.2167985

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/14747731.2023.2167985

© 2023 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Published online: 12 Feb 2023.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 2398

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Citing articles: 11 View citing articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rglo20

GLOBALIZATIONS
2024, VOL. 21, NO. 6, 1092–1107
https://doi.org/10.1080/14747731.2023.2167985

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

Renewable energy and EU-led authoritarian neoliberalization: small hydropower in Rakita, Serbia and the upscaling of environmental struggles

Aleksandra Piletić

Department of Media Studies, University of Amsterdam, Amsterdam, Netherlands

ABSTRACT
In light of the recent rise of authoritarianism and processes of 'democratic backsliding' in the Balkans (and other parts of CEE), the EU has projected an image of itself as a bastion of democracy and a counterweight to authoritarian tendencies and regimes. In contrast, this article points to the ways in which the EU – through its enlargement strategy – has legitimized authoritarian practices in candidate states. These practices have been inherently linked to the adoption of the EU acquis communautaire and deepening processes of neoliberal restructuring. In Serbia, the mandated transition to renewable energy, and the associated rise in small hydropower as a solution for meeting renewable energy targets, has led to an intensification of state-sponsored violence and coercion. By focusing on a small hydropower development in Rakita, Serbia, this paper highlights the inherently multiscalar nature of authoritarian state power and potential new avenues for contestation.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 31 May 2022
Accepted 10 January 2023

KEYWORDS
Authoritarian neoliberalism; renewable energy; EU; small hydropower; Rakita; Serbia

In the political science literature, the recent rise of authoritarianism in Central and Eastern Europe has been associated with growing 'illiberalism' and processes of 'democratic backsliding' (e.g. Bochsler & Juon, 2020; Bustikova & Guasti, 2017; Sedelmeier, 2014). Authoritarian regimes, contained within, and originating in dynamics internal to, individual nation-states, have been portrayed as anomalies within the broader European project, and juxtaposed with the liberal democracies of the EU. The rise of authoritarianism in Serbia has been attributed to the lingering effects of autocratic rule during the 1990s, which is said to have precluded the success of democratization efforts during the 2000s, and ultimately paved the way for the ascent of autocrat Aleksandar Vučić in the early 2010s (Castaldo, 2020; Dolenec, 2013). And while some literature has acknowledged that these authoritarian dynamics are not exclusively homemade, ultimately the EU is only said to play a role insofar as it turns a blind eye to them in exchange for stability in the region (Bieber, 2018).

In contrast, this paper argues that authoritarian governance should be understood as inseparable from neoliberalization and the ways in which national-level actors have responded to impulsions at the supranational scale. In fact, the EU has actively nurtured authoritarian practices in the Balkans. A central way in which this has played out is by mandating the transposition and implementation

CONTACT Aleksandra Piletić alexpiletic@gmail.com

© 2023 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits non-commercial re-use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, and is not altered, transformed, or built upon in any way.

of the *acquis communautaire* – the entire body of EU law – as a precondition to accession. The adoption of the EU energy *acquis* in particular – and the associated transition to renewable energy – has seen an intensification of authoritarian practices, amid deepening neoliberalization. Renewable energy projects – such as small hydropower plants (SHPPs) – have triggered the privatization of natural resources and the emergence of new, lucrative sources of capital post-2008 crisis. This has ultimately benefited existing elites and clientelist structures close to – or within – the authoritarian state and has been marked by renewed forms of violence and coercion. At the same time, it has had ambivalent effects on helping candidate states meet renewable energy targets and has rather been marked by irreversible forms of environmental destruction.

In order to fully understand authoritarian practices in the Serbian context, I therefore argue that we must look away from national dynamics and the rise of current president Aleksandar Vučić, as is traditionally done in the literature. While Vučić has certainly played a key role in solidifying authoritarian neoliberalization in Serbia (Piletić, 2022), an exclusive focus on his rule is too narrow in scope and blinds us to the constitutive role played by the EU, particularly through its enlargement politics. I focus on the role of EU accession commitments through the Energy Community, as well as lending institutions like the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD) and the European Investment Bank (EIB), in exerting supranational control over energy production and mandating the establishment of a new energy regime.

A SHPP investment in Rakita, a sparsely populated village in the southeastern part of Serbia, offers a particularly valuable entry point for studying these dynamics. Despite the investment's small scale and local character, the Rakita SHPP demonstrates the inherently multiscalar nature of authoritarian practices and their interplay with neoliberal forms of accumulation. It also allows us to capture authoritarian neoliberal tendencies through the lens of a simultaneous strengthening *and* weakening of the state, pointing to how the intensification of coercive practices has been accompanied by new forms of resistance and contestation (Bruff, 2014, p. 124). Namely, the construction of the SHPP in Rakita encountered fierce contestation from locals and was, thanks to their multi-year efforts, ultimately halted in 2020. Moreover, the struggles in Rakita have ignited a broader environmental movement in the country, which has worked to upscale the contestation of authoritarian power to the national and supranational levels (albeit in a limited way).

In the following section, I discuss the conceptualization of authoritarianism that I adopt, drawing on key contributions to the study of authoritarian neoliberalism (Bruff, 2014, 2016, 2017; Bruff & Tansel, 2019; Tansel, 2017) as well as Gurol, Jenss, Rodríguez, Schuetze & Wetterich's call in this special issue to adopt a practice-based reading of authoritarian power. In the second section, I outline and summarize key features of small hydropower plants, and their role in the promotion of renewable energy, particularly in EU candidate countries. The third section then discusses the dynamics of small hydropower development in Serbia as part of its Energy Community commitments, as well as the key role of multilateral lending institutions such as the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD) and the European Investment Bank (EIB) in promoting small hydropower, both of which have intertwined with authoritarian modes of governance at the national scale. The last section traces these dynamics in the case of the SHPP development in Rakita, Serbia, pointing to the ways in which the illegality of the Rakita SHPP, coupled with an intensification of policing and coercion in the village, has sparked the emergence of a budding environmental movement with a national reach.

Theorizing authoritarian neoliberalism elsewhere

As Gurol, Jenss, Rodríguez, Schuetze & Wetterich argue in the introduction to this special issue, instead of adopting a regime-centered understanding of authoritarianism that circumscribes authoritarian dynamics within the nation-state, it is more productive to understand it as a complex web of multiscalar authoritarian practices (5). Conceptualizing authoritarianism through the lens of practices signals a methodological reorientation away from binary understandings of authoritarianism (i.e. democracy/authoritarianism) and seeks to capture the 'multitude of authoritarian actors and practices beyond or below the level of the state' (Gurol, Jenss, Rodríguez, Schuetze, & Wetterich, forthcoming, p. 3). In order to grasp the complexities of contemporary forms of authoritarian power, Gurol et al. argue that it is necessary to rely on 'new starting points and/or notions of context' (3). This epistemological call to 'look elsewhere' is immensely useful, *especially* when it seems that a traditional nation state- or regime-centered methodology is sufficiently equipped to capture authoritarian power dynamics. An exclusive focus on actors at the national scale can never adequately capture contemporary forms of authoritarianism, as the latter are inherently multiscalar and polycentric. Ultimately, a practice-oriented approach is a call to reorient our attention to formerly overlooked spaces, scales and actors on our quest to understand authoritarian power.

Furthermore, these authoritarian practices are anchored to a particular spatio-temporal conjuncture. While neoliberalism has always shown a proclivity towards coercive and authoritarian tactics, the post-2008 crisis period has seen a systemic emergence of authoritarianism in response to neoliberalism's declining supremacy. As Bruff and Tansel (2019) argue, authoritarian practices have been deployed in this context to shield neoliberalism from popular pressure. Rather than neutralize resistance and dissent via concessions, authoritarian neoliberalism frequently involves direct efforts to exclude and marginalize subordinate social groups (Bruff, 2014, p. 116). This understanding allows us to transcend the false dichotomy between authoritarian regimes and liberal democracies, and to theorize authoritarian practices as intimately linked to neoliberal accumulation. And while authoritarian neoliberalism entails an intensification of state violence, it spans a variety of scales, both above and below the level of the *nation-state*. Bruff (2017, p. 149) makes a convincing case for looking towards the EU – and governance practices 'seemingly far removed from what we associate with the term "authoritarianism"' – for understanding post-crisis coercive tendencies in the European Union. He charts authoritarian neoliberal tendencies inherent in EU governance mechanisms through the mobilization of juridical power to both constitutionalize austerity and violate EU law (2016) and through the hardening of 'soft' EU law (2017).

Indeed, a variety of new entanglements have appeared between EU and various member states in the post-crisis period, resulting in experiments with increasingly authoritarian modalities of governance. Declining legitimacy and trust in supranational institutions in the aftermath of the financial crisis, particularly in the European context, has led supranational actors to exert downward pressure on national governments, compelling them to contain and absorb tensions caused by popular discontent at lower scales. Post-crisis forms of authoritarian power have therefore to a considerable degree been designed and orchestrated in response to disciplinary impulsions originating at the supranational scale (for instance, commitments through EU membership or candidacy, multilateral regulatory frameworks (e.g. WTO); regional trade agreements (e.g. NAFTA); etc.). Governments have deployed a variety of constitutional and legal mechanisms, as well as purely coercive ones, to quell dissent and re-establish legitimacy at different scales of governance.

This paper extends this understanding of national and supranational entanglements by charting the EU's coercive practices in *non*-EU spaces. Processes of European integration – i.e. the adoption of the *acquis communautaire* and the Copenhagen criteria – have served as a key mechanism for the EU to project its power eastward (Jones & Clark, 2010, p. 72), as well as instigate and deepen neoliberal reforms in candidate countries (Bohle, 2006). One domain in which the EU has actively asserted its interests is energy production – by extending internal EU energy market rules (i.e. the energy *acquis*) to candidate countries even prior to their accession.

A particularly relevant regulation adopted as part of these commitments is the Framework Directive 2009/28/EC, which sets mandatory targets for the overall share of energy from renewable sources. A central way that candidate countries – which normally lack the ability to raise funds for large state-led renewable energy projects – have sought to meet these targets is by promoting investments in small hydropower. This has entailed the privatization of (untouched) river water, previously used for sustaining the livelihoods of local communities. The privatization of natural resources has deepened processes of neoliberal restructuring through what Harvey (2004) has termed *accumulation by dispossession*,[1] a process recent literature has also dubbed 'water grabbing' (Franco et al., 2013, pp. 1653–4).

Water grabbing via small hydropower has been further incentivized by the EBRD and the EIB – the EU's two multilateral lending institutions known for their role in expanding and deepening neoliberal processes across Europe's immediate periphery (Shields, 2020). They have earmarked significant funds for projects of this kind, particularly in the years following the 2008 financial crisis. Under the guidance of the European Economic Recovery Plan – the EU Commission's response to the financial crisis – their lending volume for projects supporting renewable energy was increased (European Parliament, 2009). This has rendered renewables not only a mechanism for meeting EU accession goals, but also a lucrative new source of capital in the context of the post-crisis recession.

However, as Bieler (2021) has showed, 'water grabbing' is not unilinear, but is a highly fragmented and contested process. This is especially the case because water is an inherently 'uncooperative commodity' – as Bakker (2005, p. 559) argues, its 'biophysical, spatial and sociocultural characteristics render it particularly resistant to commodification.' The very *nature of water* renders efforts to neoliberalize it conducive to resistance. Post-2008 crisis, EU candidate states' efforts to implement core EU energy legislation to meet the criteria for accession – central to which have been processes of 'water grabbing' – have therefore necessitated the deployment of increasingly authoritarian practices and modes of governance, particularly in the local communities where these small hydropower developments have taken place.

This echoes Bruff and Tansel's (2019, p. 234) conceptualization of authoritarian practices as inherently crisis-ridden and contradictory, enhancing possibilities for resistance *as well as* domination. It also reiterates previous work arguing that the post-2008 period in Serbia has seen a process of authoritarian neoliberal rescaling whereby the national scale has been restructured in a more coercive direction, while the local scale has been rendered more permeable to contestation (Piletić, 2022, p. 289). The case of renewable energy in the Serbian context also makes it clear that, in the neoliberal era, authoritarian actors embedded at the national scale are never *just* national – they are always reflexive of and responsive to impulsions at higher scales. Conversely, supranational social forces are contingent on the legitimacy they receive from actors embedded at the national scale. Authoritarian power therefore zigzags between scales, as it attempts to smooth out the contradictions and tensions inherent in processes of neoliberal restructuring.

Finally, this understanding of the authoritarian role of the EU is complemented by the notion of customary illegality, that is, 'the social acceptability and habitual practice of illegality in doing business, across goods and services' (Gregson & Crang, 2017). Gregson and Crang (2017, p. 208) highlight the importance of focusing on illegality as a constitutive part of business activities as well as stressing the role of organized crime within the global economy. 'Customary illegality' therefore alerts us to the fact that illegality does not run parallel to the 'regular' economy, nor should it be understood as confined to the economies of single nations but rather that 'the global economy is continually touched by illegality; illegality runs through it' (Gregson & Crang, 2017, pp. 209–210). Adopting this view allows us to conceptualize criminality and crime in Serbia as transcending the confines of the nation-state, as well as constitutively linked to 'benevolent' EU policies, particularly those in the domain of energy production.

Dynamics of small hydropower development

There is no universal definition of small hydropower, and understandings of what makes it 'small' tend to vary, but the general trend has been to classify SHPPs as installations with a capacity of less than 10MW (Couto & Olden, 2018, p. 93). While SHPPs have been around for decades, they have been aggressively promoted in recent years as one of the best clean and green sources of energy. At least 82,891 SHPPs were either operating or under construction in 150 countries in 2018, and this number could potentially triple if 'all potential capacity' were to be developed in the years to come (Couto & Olden, 2018). However, even though SHPPs represent the vast majority of hydropower plants worldwide, they contribute only 11% of the global electricity generation capacity based on hydropower (Couto & Olden, 2018).

The 2019 World Small Hydropower Development Report, jointly drafted by the United Nations Industrial Development Organization (UNIDO) and the International Center on Small Hydro Power (ICSHP), reports that small hydropower has emerged as 'an integral part of a broader strategy to promote development whilst reducing greenhouse gas emissions and promoting greater energy independence' (Liu, Liu, Wang, & Kremere, 2019, p. 6). Scholarly work on the topic has hailed SHPPs as 'one of the most environmentally benign energy technologies available' (Paish, 2002, p. 538) with some even deeming it 'renewable energy with zero emissions' (Zhou et al., 2009, p. 1078). Contrasted with large hydro technologies which generally require the building of large dams (and therefore large-scale concrete and rock structures across major rivers), SHPPs are praised for their lesser socioecological impact (Gleick, 1992 as cited in Couto & Olden, 2018, p. 91). SHPPs are based on 'run-of-river'/diversion technologies which are much smaller in scale and generally do not require the construction of environmentally invasive dams (Paish, 2002, p. 538). And while some adverse impacts of SHPPs are acknowledged by the agencies and institutions that promote them, these impacts are usually deemed inconsequential because of the plants' small scale.

However, research has shown that the vast environmental damage SHPPs cause only becomes apparent when it is compared to LHPPs *given a similar volume of energy production* (Abbasi & Abbasi, 2011; Bakken et al., 2012; Kibler & Tullos, 2013). When compared in this way, it is clear that biophysical impact of SHPPs may even exceed that of LHPPs,[2] particularly with regard to habitat and hydrologic change (Kibler & Tullos, 2013). SHPPs fragment streams, divert most water out of the channel and towards a powerhouse, and therefore leave long stretches of the river with considerably reduced flow (Opperman, 2018). This not only 'degrades the aesthetic beauty of a free-flowing stream in a bucolic valley' but also has major ecological consequences for river ecosystems,

as well as social consequences for rural communities which have depended on the rivers for sustenance for generations (Opperman, 2018).

While the construction of SHPPs has also gained traction within the EU following the adoption of a series of EU directives promoting renewable energy production, it has not proceeded with such intensity as in EU candidate countries. In EU member states, a number of checks exist for situations where the construction of SHPPs is likely to cause environmental devastation – in particular, EU's Framework Directive 2000/60/EC imposes strict rules on any hydromorphological alteration of watercourses and eco-systems (Zelenáková et al., 2018, pp. 2–3). Therefore, a layer of protection exists for EU member states, and the European Commission and the European Court of Justice can intervene if national legal systems fail to uphold EU law (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018, p. 38). In 2015, for instance, the European Commission launched an infringement procedure against Romania because SHPPs were being constructed in protected areas in the Faragas Mountains, and a similar situation occurred in Slovakia (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018, p. 3).

This is not the case in EU candidate countries, where energy directives promoting renewables are deeply entangled with the EU accession process, and European lending bodies such as the EIB and the EBRD earmark large sums of money for the transition to renewable energy. EU candidate countries are strongly incentivized to facilitate investments in renewable sources of energy at all costs; meeting accession criteria therefore goes hand-in-hand with loosening environmental protections and establishing a lucrative business environment for renewable energy investments. In the following sections, I trace how EU-mandated shifts to renewable energy have rendered SHPPs a particularly profitable investment for individuals close to and within state structures. In Serbia, this has triggered a loosening of environmental checks and balances as well as an intensification of coercive tactics to preempt and quash contestation at the local scale.

The intertwining of EU accession agreements and authoritarian governance in Serbia

As mentioned above, Serbia's state-sponsored move to ramp up the building of SHPPs stems directly from its EU accession commitments and its membership in the Energy Community. The Energy Community is an organization established in 2005 between the European Union and a number of countries located primarily in Southeastern Europe and the Black Sea region[3] with the purpose of establishing an 'integrated pan-European energy market' (Energy Community). Its key objective is the extension of 'EU internal energy market rules and principles' to the aforementioned countries 'on the basis of a legally binding framework' (Energy Community). In 2009, the EU Renewable Energy Directive set binding national targets for renewables in an effort to reduce CO_2 emissions by 20%, increase the share of renewable energy to 20% and achieve energy savings of 20% or more (Directive 2009/28/EC).

For the purpose of reducing its reliance on coal[4] and meeting its Energy Community commitments, in 2014 the Serbian parliament adopted a new Energy Law intended to encourage investments in renewable energy (*Zakon o energetici*, član 70). In particular, it introduced a new category of 'privileged power producers' who would be subsidized for the production of renewable energy. These subsidies were designed in the form of feed-in tariffs (FITs) – policy mechanisms designed to promote market-based investments in renewable energy by guaranteeing above-market energy prices to small scale producers. Feed-in tariffs tend to be offered for longer time periods, locking in a guaranteed favourable rate for investors (oftentimes for a period of 15–20 years). In Serbia, FITs were approved for periods of 12 years at a rate of 0.081 dinars per kWh,[5] meaning

that the guaranteed tariffs could not be revoked by the state at any time, and the guaranteed supplier, Elektroprivreda Srbije (EPS), would be legally obligated to purchase the manufactured energy (Ćetković, 2019). Despite these considerable subsidies – and therefore the enormous cost of the electricity manufactured by SHPPs – statistics show that in 2018 they contributed to the production of only 0.7% of all Serbian energy (Đorđević, 2020b).

While these subsidies were intended to promote investments in a range of renewable energy sources (e.g. wind, solar, biomass), small hydropower plants emerged as the most viable for a number of reasons. First of all, the country's topographic and hydrological characteristics make it conducive to this particular form of energy production – run-of-river/diversion SHPPs rely on small rivers with steep falls (usually rivers situated in hilly or mountainous areas) which are common in southern and western parts of Serbia (Panić et al., 2013, p. 342). In addition, unlike solar and wind power, there is no maximum cap for feed-in tariffs for energy originating from hydropower sources (Gallop, 2020), making SHPPs a more lucrative investment. And finally, it is comparatively much easier to access funds for investing in SHPPs than in large scale windfarms or photovoltaic power stations; generous funds have been earmarked for SHPPs by multilateral lending institutions like the EBRD and the EIB, making it much easier to invest in this type of renewable energy compared to others.

Data from 2018 shows that the EBRD has supported the construction of at least 61 SHPPs in Southeast Europe with €126 million in loans since 2005 (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018, p. 5). During the same period, the EIB has provided €445 million for the construction of 11 plants in the region (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018). The EIB has also provided over €22 million to at least 22 small and mini hydropower plants via commercial banks through financial intermediaries whose final clients could not be traced (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018). The EIB tends to operate by outsourcing a large part of its lending to intermediaries (between 2016 and 2018, 36% of its lending in third countries was outsourced), along with the monitoring and due diligence for projects it has funded (Bankwatch Network, 2019). In addition to providing loans, multilateral banks like the EBRD have also offered logistical support for the construction of SHPPs, e.g. by advertising invitations for tenders on behalf of SHPP investors that have been awarded EBRD funds (EBRD, 2018). By mobilizing large quantities of capital, the EBRD and EIB have provided strong financial incentives for investments in SHPPs and have therefore played a central role in the overall rise of SHPP investments in the region.

In Serbia, these strong financial incentives have intertwined domestically with loosely enforced regulations to generate an institutional milieu which has reinscribed processes of authoritarian neoliberal restructuring. This can be clearly observed in the implementation of the administrative procedure required for the construction of SHPPs, which is lengthy and requires gaining approval and permits from a number of state authorities (both at local and national levels). A series of environmental studies and approvals have to be obtained before a construction permit can be issued for any given SHPP – this includes a hydrological study, approval by the Hydrometeorological Service of Serbia, as well as approval by the competent local body in charge of ecological and environmental issues. However, it has been reported that at least 24 of the 116 SHPPs that were completed in 2019 – one in five – were built *without* key environmental permits (Đorđević, 2020b). There were certain cases (e.g. SHPP Jovanovići) where construction even began without a *construction permit* (Insajder, 2019). It is most likely that disregard for regulations pertaining to environmental, construction and other relevant standards occurs because investors have strong connections in the government and/or within the issuing authority. In fact, feed-in tariffs for renewables schemes have a history of being linked to corruption, signalling that the illegal and illicit

are not an aberration, but are a constitutive part of certain incentives in the transition to renewable energy (Gregson & Crang, 2017). As Janez Kopac, director of the Energy Community Secretariat has argued: 'Wherever you have feed-in tariffs, the business can be taken over by a mafia … Only firms that are close to the state can profit in this manner' (Gregson & Crang, 2017).

The link between the highest echelons of government and SHPP investors is clear from the distribution of payouts for renewable energy provision which has, between 2013 and 2016, amounted to over €41.6 million (Kostić & Đorđević, 2018). Out of this amount, €7.2 million has gone to companies associated with Nikola Petrović, close friend of Serbian president Aleksandar Vučić, while €14 million has been paid out to the previously mentioned national power utility, EPS, which – much like all other state-owned enterprises in the country – is also under Vučić's (indirect) control (Kostić & Đorđević, 2018). In 2019, approximately €854,000 was paid out to W&W Energy, a company linked to the brother of Serbian Prime Minister Ana Brnabić through his close business partner, Miodrag Mirčetić. W&W Energy owns and operates two SHPPs in the town of Nova Varoš (Tomić, 2020). In a 2020 interview, Mirčetić explained that he saw his investment in small hydropower as an opportunity to 'diversify his portfolio' by tapping into the cheap 'green' loans offered by the World Bank and the EBRD (Tomić, 2020).

While the main beneficiaries of the green energy subsidies have been close allies of the Serbian government, the remaining investors are difficult to trace because of the opaque ownership structures of SHPPs. There is no central government registry which allows public access to this data, and banks (both multilateral and commercial) have refused to reveal data about loan recipients. However, investigative reporting in the country has revealed that, apart from direct links to the highest echelons of government, SHPPs have served as lucrative investments for various individuals with a history of criminal dealings. For instance, Branislav Savić, a Montenegrin businessman who has been found guilty of stealing 7 million euros from a municipality in Montenegro invested in a SHPP in the Serbian town of Kamena Gora, while convicted narcotrafficker Miloš Pandrc who has had strong ties to Serbian drug lord Darko Šarić was appointed – while in prison – as a representative of the company that built the SHPP Virovci in Bosilegrad (Đorđević, 2020a). This points to the 'customary illegality' inherent in SHPP investments, and the widespread acceptance of illegal business dealings in the mainstream economy and EU energy politics. SHPPs have acted as a key conduit for the transfer of public wealth and EU loans to criminal actors, legitimizing them and the authoritarian practices that they are associated with. In the next section, I take a closer look at the construction of the SHPP located in in Rakita and the simultaneous strengthening and weakening of the state which it has involved.

SHPP Zvonce, the struggle in Rakita and the emergence of a national environmental movement

One of the SHPP investments that has received the most media attention is 'Zvonce', located in Rakita, a village situated in the sparsely populated Bulgarian border region in southeastern Serbia. The Zvonce SHPP forms part of a constellation of SHPPs built on the mountainous terrain of Stara Planina, a protected natural park. Despite its remoteness, distance from the capital city and size (it numbers approximately 200 households), Rakita has become symbolic of the broader, nation-wide struggle against SHPPs (Filipov, 2018). The dynamic activism of local residents and their success in contributing to the halting of the construction of the Zvonce SHPP has set a powerful example for SHPP contestation efforts elsewhere and has acted as catalyst for the emergence of a budding environmental movement. The example of Rakita also shows us that authoritarian tactics do not

originate locally but are intimately bound to processes occurring at higher scales. Rakita therefore offers a powerful lens for studying multiscalar authoritarian dynamics and the increasing permeability of the local scale to contestation.

The construction of the SHPP in Rakita was financed by a loan issued by UniCredit bank (Vejnović & Gallop, 2018, p. 21), a longstanding regional lending partner of the EBRD (Vlajčić, 2019). The investor – Goran Belić, a lawyer from Belgrade – circumvented numerous key regulations and procedures in order to obtain the permits necessary to begin the construction of the SHPP. One of the key prerequisites for obtaining a construction permit is the environmental impact assessment – a key mechanism of environmental protection envisaged under Serbian law. Belić was granted an exemption for conducting this assessment by the Municipality of Babušnica, based on a variety of erroneous claims cited in the exemption application (Rajić et al., 2020). In spite of this, as well as the fact that the application was incomplete (RERI, 2019), Belić was granted an exemption, indicating that he likely had strong connections within the municipality and/or key figures within higher echelons of government.

From the outset, the construction of SHPP Zvonce was fiercely contested by the villagers from Rakita who feared its detrimental environmental effects (Bjeletić, 2017). Throughout 2018, protests remained local in character although protesters expressed the need to scale up their protests; they complained that they were left to their own devices and felt invisible both to the municipality and the state (N1 Beograd, 2018). Gradually, the construction of the SHPP in Rakita gained broader attention and drew increasing support from other parts of the Stara Planina region. A grassroots initiative named *Defend the Rivers of Stara Planina* (DRSP) – a group of citizens who organized via a Facebook group – started to play a central role by uniting contestation efforts against SHPPs throughout the Stara Planina region. DRSP united villagers and environmental activists around the common goal of contesting SHPPs, arguing that the latter would cause permanent environmental degradation in Stara Planina (Odbranimo reke Stare Planine, 2022).

Throughout this period, a variety of non-state and state forces policed the area, deploying coercive and violent tactics to quash opposition to the construction of the SHPP in Rakita. The SHPP investor hired private security to patrol the surrounding area and intimidate the local population (Đurić, 2018; Stojanović, 2019). Numerous instances of private security physically assaulting residents who were peacefully protesting the construction of the SHPP were reported. Activists were also charged with misdemeanors and fined for their presence at anti-SHPP gatherings. In 2018, for instance, two activists were charged for failing to report a public gathering for posting an invitation to organize a cleaning initiative at the Rakita and Vučidel rivers on Facebook which led to the spontaneous disruption of the construction of the SHPP (Janačković, 2019; Marinković, 2019). The investor also sued villagers and activists for slander, emotional distress, disturbance of possession, and it is believed that he was significantly assisted in this aim by the local police (Odbranimo reke stare planine, 2021, p. 9). As one of the 88-year-old local residents stated to the media, 'I have survived different governments, but I have never experienced such violence' (Čubrilo, 2019).

Ultimately, however, efforts by the state to quell the protests were not successful. Rakita villagers and DRSP activists scaled up their contestation efforts to the national arena by compelling the Environment Protection Institute of Serbia to conduct an inspection of the Rakita River in the fall of 2018. During this visit, representatives of the Institute confirmed the presence of two highly protected species in the river and determined that further efforts to build the SHPP would endanger them (Odbranimo reke stare planine, 2021, p. 6; Rajić et al., 2020). At this time, it was also determined that illegal SHPP construction caused a landslide as well as an irreversible loss of vegetation in one part of the construction site (Rajić et al., 2020). This led the Ministry for Environmental

Protection, as well as the local municipality, to order the investor to halt the construction of the SHPP and return the river to its original state, i.e. to remove the pipes from the riverbed (Rajić et al., 2020) – a significant victory for the locals and the activists.

Despite this victory, these two Ministry decisions were never formally enforced by Serbian state organs, allowing the investor to continue with the construction of the SHPP in 2019 (Đukić Pejić, 2020). Throughout this time, both the investor and the police continued to harass and assault the residents of Rakita. One of the leading activists and local villagers who opposed the SHPP in Rakita received over 60 misdemeanor charges (Selaković et al., 2021, p. 18). New efforts to scale up protests were made by DRSP leaders who chose to organize a series of protests directed against the construction of SHPPs in Belgrade. These protests were attended by Belgrade residents increasingly aware of the destructive impact of SHPPs, as well as residents of villages impacted by SHPPs throughout the country who travelled to the capital for that occasion (Bogdanović, 2019). Activists aimed to put pressure on President Vučić, demanding a moratorium on the construction of SHPPs throughout the country (ibid.). However, the protests were not just targeted at the national government – they also targeted the financial intermediaries involved in lending SHPP investors funds (Đorđević & Šarić, 2019). Protesters targeted banks like UniCredit, Erste, Banca Intesa and Société Générale calling on them to refrain from financing projects in protected natural areas (Đorđević & Šarić, 2019).

DRSP activists persisted in their efforts to engage with actors at higher scales, and ultimately key organizational support arrived from a range of Belgrade-based organizations engaged in local community struggles, such as Civic Initiatives and Savski Nasip (Jovanović, 2019b). In 2018, support also arrived from the European Water Movement – a continent-wide network of water movements fighting for water as a common (EWM, 2018a). The EWM offered support to the fight against SHPPs in Serbia; in October 2018, in collaboration with the Rosa Luxembourg Stiftung, EWM organized a workshop on the subject of protecting rivers and communities from dam and hydropower plant construction in Belgrade, uniting environmental activists from the Balkans with those from other parts of Europe (EWM, 2018b). The following year, the movement received public support from key scientists from the University of Belgrade who publicly denounced SHPPs and pointed to their destructive environmental impact (Petrović, 2019; Simonović, 2019). This series of efforts to upscale contestation were highly significant as they legitimized the struggle against SHPPs at national and supranational scales (Georgievski, 2020).

In August 2020, after years of protests and appeals to the government, the DRSP turned to direct action tactics to enforce the decision of the Environment Protection Institute – by organizing an action to destroy the SHPP pipe that the Rakita River was being diverted into (Đukić Pejić, 2020). Environmental activists, residents of nearby villages and towns, and other concerned citizens across the country travelled to Rakita to support local villagers and organizations in their efforts to remove the illegal construction. They used shovels and other tools to break the SHPP pipe, and while they didn't succeed in entirely removing the 2-ton construction, they damaged it beyond repair, halting the construction of the SHPP. This was one of the first instances in which local activists succeeded in their efforts to upscale resistance, successfully mobilizing activists from throughout the region and country.

In addition to the Rakita victory, DRSP has succeeded in contesting the construction of SHPPs elsewhere in the region as well. Pirot, a town not far from Rakita, removed all planned SHPP construction locations from the town's spatial plan in 2020 (Nešić, 2020), thereby halting the construction of 84 SHPPs throughout the Stara Planina region for a period of 15 years (Georgievski, 2020). The local government was initially dismissive of the demands of the local activists but changed its course in response to strong anti-SHPP sentiments which spread throughout the region. As

Aleksandar Jovanović Ćuta, one of the leaders of the ORSP, pointed out, the Pirot government adopted this spatial plan

> under pressure … from the three-year long protests on the Stara Planina, war-like situations in certain locations, tens of village protests – people no longer want to permit their water to be stolen, their air to be polluted and their forests to be decimated. (Nešić, 2020)

Further efforts to scale up the protests occurred in Belgrade in the spring of 2021 under the name 'Ecological Uprising' (Ekološki ustanak). These protests drew attention to the ecological destruction caused by SHPPs throughout the country but gradually incorporated a variety of other local environmental struggles, such as the battle to save Košutnjak – an urban park and forest in Belgrade – from residential developments, the struggle against lithium mining by multinational giant Rio Tinto in Western Serbia, struggles against environmental destruction in Fruška Gora, a national park in northern Serbia, and numerous others (Glas Amerike, 2021).

For the first time in Serbia's recent history, environmental issues had become a central national political issue (Janković, 2022). The wave of environmental protests catalyzed by the opposition to SHPPs in the Stara Planina region heightened nation-wide citizen awareness of environmental issues and played a key role in shaping the political landscape in the wake of the 2022 parliamentary and presidential elections (Janković, 2022). *Ecological Uprising*, which grew from a series of national protests into a movement, joined forces with a number of other local citizen initiatives, and represented one of the first meaningful left green political options in Serbia (Janković, 2022). Furthermore, in response to the protests and pressure coming from local citizen groups, multilateral lending institutions involved in funding SHPPs have also been compelled to change their lending practices. The EBRD has tightened environmental and disclosure standards for all hydropower projects: from the beginning of 2020 onwards, all high-risk projects – including SHPPs – were submitted to additional checks, requiring them to meet higher environmental standards (Jovanović, 2019a). The EBRD now also requires its financial intermediaries to publicly disclose information on the environmental and social risks of any of the funded projects, as well as the proposed measures to mitigate these risks (Janković, 2019a). Finally, Serbia has revoked feed-in tariff subsidies for small hydropower in early 2020, removing incentives for new SHPP investments (Gallop, 2020).

While success in scaling up protests regionally, nationally, and even supranationally was substantial – particularly given Serbia's prior lack of green movements and activism – it remains incomplete. The protests have failed to engage with the material foundations of the authoritarian violence experienced by the residents of Rakita and other communities affected by SHPP-related water grabbing. They focused on the illegality of SHPPs, and the need to protect the rule of law (Đukić Pejić, 2020; Jovanović, 2019b) which painted an incomplete and misleading picture of SHPP dynamics in Serbia. As the results of the 2022 parliamentary and presidential elections show, it is rather the radical right that has succeeded in narrating the multiplicity of social, economic, and environmental crises in Serbia (Anđelković, 2022; Rujević, 2022).

Conclusion

In recent years, the rise of authoritarianism in Serbia has been characterized as process of 'democratic backsliding' – a move away from EU norms and values – orchestrated by the government of Aleksandar Vučić. This article has argued that we must look beyond national dynamics, and adopt a genuinely multiscalar perspective, to understand the full scope of authoritarian practices in Serbia. Authoritarian practices are inseparable from ongoing processes of neoliberal restructuring and

must be understood as a complex intertwining of national and supranational processes, rather than a solely national phenomenon. This also helps us transcend the legal/illegal binary in conceptualizing the corruption and criminality involved in many of the Serbian SHPPs, pointing to their customary illegality. Serbia's ongoing relationship with the EU, particularly its EU integration efforts, has played a particularly central role in incentivizing and nurturing the intensification of authoritarian practices at lower scales. By encouraging investments in renewable energy sources like SHPPs, the EU has not only politically supported processes of authoritarian neoliberalization in candidate countries like Serbia, but it has also financially underwritten them through the lending practices of key lending institutions like the EBRD and the EIB.

The SHPP located in Rakita serves as a powerful analytical entry point for studying the multiscalar features of authoritarian neoliberal power. While the intensification of authoritarian practices is generally associated with the strengthening of the state, the example of Rakita demonstrates that the state has simultaneously become more permeable to contestation as well, evidenced by the intensification of protests and resistance on multiple scales across a variety of arenas. Although SHPP resistance efforts were initially confined to the village of Rakita and orchestrated by the villagers themselves, persistent efforts to scale up protest actions have drawn in of other local citizen initiatives (e.g. Savski Nasip, Civic Initiatives), members of the scientific community (e.g. University of Belgrade professors), international allies (e.g. European Water Movement), and ordinary citizens across the country. The construction of SHPP Zvonce was ultimately halted, and numerous other SHPPs in the region were banned, while environmental issues took centre stage nationally in an unprecedented way. Looking beyond the national scale helps us understand that authoritarian practices are not monolithic, complete, or definite – they are contested and contestable, and within themselves contain the seeds of their own demise. Opposing them, however, requires better efforts at narrating and articulating their link both to ongoing efforts to extend and deepen neoliberal restructuring, as well as their anchoring to commitments at the supranational scale.

Researchers interested in authoritarian neoliberalism might wish to further explore how recent efforts to appropriate nature to secure ongoing neoliberal accumulation have triggered the deployment of authoritarian practices. This paper has dealt with the subject of 'water grabbing,' but studies of 'land grabbing' (i.e. ongoing efforts to commodify and privatize land) would also immensely benefit from a perspective attuned to authoritarian neoliberalism as a multiscalar phenomenon. Further research might also wish to explore how the leveraging of natural resources in the context of the (neoliberal) 'green transition' has led to the intensification of violence and coercion. Lithium, for instance, has been hailed as a way out of oil dependence as a key component in the production of electric vehicles but has been associated with environmental degradation and a disempowerment of local, indigenous populations in countries like Argentina, Bolivia and Chile.

Notes

1. Extending Marx's concept of primitive accumulation to present-day dynamics of capitalist accumulation, Harvey (2004, p. 74) argues that predatory practices do not belong to an 'original stage' of capitalism but are rather an integral part of the long historical geography of capitalist accumulation.
2. It is worth noting that, unlike SHPPs, LHPPs require hundreds of millions to billions of euros in investment as well as long periods of construction and development (International Energy Agency [IEA], 2021, p. 20). As a result, they are not as lucrative to private sector investors as SHPPs which have lower investment requirements and frequently benefit from policy mechanisms such as feed-in tariffs and auctions (International Energy Agency [IEA], 2021, p. 21). So while there has been a

boom in SHPP investments in Serbia (and the Western Balkans in general) in the post-2008 crisis period, there have been virtually no substantial investments in LHPPs.

3. In particular: Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo, North Macedonia, Moldova, Montenegro, Serbia, Ukraine and Georgia (with Armenia, Norway and Turkey acting as observers).
4. Until then, Serbia's electricity market was dominated by the national power utility, EPS (Elektroprivreda Srbije) which owns all large generation capacities and supplies most consumers in the country (Bankwatch). Subsidiaries of EPS own the country's two largest coal-fired power stations, Kostolac and Kolubara.
5. This rate was increased to 0.093 dinars/kWh in 2015 and in December 2020 to 0.437 dinars/kWh.

Acknowledgements

I would like to thank Alke Jenss, as well as three reviewers, for very useful feedback and suggestions. The paper has also benefitted from the expert editorial guidance of Julia Gurol and Fabricio Rodríguez.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on contributor

Aleksandra Piletić is a postdoctoral researcher at the University of Amsterdam. Her research interests are situated at the broad intersection between political economy and economic geography, and she is particularly interested in capitalist variety, neoliberal restructuring and urban transformations.

ORCID

Aleksandra Piletić http://orcid.org/0000-0002-3692-6601

References

Abbasi, T., & Abbasi, S. A. (2011). Small hydro and the environmental implications of its extensive utilization. *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews*, *15*(4), 2134–2143. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.rser.2010.11.050

Anđelković, N. (2022, April 4). Izbori 2022 i politika: Da li je Srbija otišla udesno i zašto. *BBC News*. https://www.bbc.com/serbian/lat/srbija-60983253

Bakken, T. H., Sundt, H., Ruud, A., & Harby, A. (2012). Development of small versus large hydropower in Norway – comparison of environmental impacts. *Energy Procedia*, *20*, 185–199. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.egypro.2012.03.019

Bakker, K. (2005). Neoliberalizing nature? Market environmentalism in water supply in England and Wales. *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, *95*(3), 542–565. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-8306.2005.00474.x

Bankwatch Network. (2019). Calling the EIB for a state-of-the-art policy on financial intermediaries. https://bankwatch.org/publication/calling-the-eib-for-a-state-of-the-art-policy-on-financial-intermediaries

Bieber, F. (2018). The rise (and fall) of Balkan stabilitocracies. *Horizons*, *10*, 176–185. https://doi.org/10.2307/48573486.

Bieler, A. (2021). *Fighting for water: Resisting privatization in Europe*. Bloomsbury Academic.

Bjeletić, G. (2017, September 9). Meštani sela Rakita brane lokalni put i reku od investitora. *N1 Serbia*. https://rs.n1info.com/vesti/a316794-mestani-sela-rakita-brane-lokalni-put-i-reku-od-investitora/

Bochsler, D., & Juon, A. (2020). Authoritarian footprints in Central and Eastern Europe. *East European Politics*, *36*(2), 167–187. https://doi.org/10.1080/21599165.2019.1698420

Bogdanović, N. (2019, September 21). Protest protiv mini hidroelektrana: Nećemo mirno gledati sahranjivanje reka. *Radio Slobodna Evropa*. https://www.slobodnaevropa.org/a/30176741.html

Bohle, D. (2006). Neoliberal hegemony, transnational capital and the terms of the EU's eastward expansion. *Capital & Class*, *30*(1), 57–86. https://doi.org/10.1177/030981680608800104

Bruff, I. (2014). The rise of authoritarian neoliberalism. *Rethinking Marxism*, *26*(1), 113–129. https://doi.org/10.1080/08935696.2013.843250

Bruff, I. (2016). Neoliberalism and authoritarianism. In S. Springer, K. Birch, & J. MacLeavy (Eds.), *The handbook of neoliberalism* (pp. 107–117). Routledge.

Bruff, I. (2017). Cease to exist? The European 'social' model and the hardening of 'soft' EU law. In C. B. Tansel (Ed.), *States of discipline: Authoritarian neoliberalism and the contested reproduction of capitalist order* (pp. 149–170). Rowman & Littlefield.

Bruff, I., & Tansel, C. B. (2019). Authoritarian neoliberalism: Trajectories of knowledge production and praxis. *Globalizations*, *16*(3), 233–244. https://doi.org/10.1080/14747731.2018.1502497

Bustikova, L., & Guasti, P. (2017). The illiberal turn or swerve in Central Europe? *Politics and Governance*, *5*(4), 166–176. https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.v5i4.1156

Castaldo, A. (2020). Back to competitive authoritarianism? Democratic backsliding in Vučić's Serbia. *Europe-Asia Studies*, *72*(1), 1617–1638. https://doi.org/10.1080/09668136.2020.1817860

Ćetković, S. (2019). Feed-in tariff. http://www.res-legal.eu/search-by-country/serbia/single/s/res-e/t/promotion/aid/feed-in-tariff-15/lastp/478/

Couto, T. B. A., & Olden, J. D. (2018). Global proliferation of small hydropower plants – science and policy. *Frontiers in Ecology and the Environment*, *16*(2), 91–100. https://doi.org/10.1002/fee.1746

Čubrilo, M. (2019, July 11). Život u ritmu čuvanja reke. *Vreme*, issue no. 1488. https://www.vreme.com/vreme/zivot-u-ritmu-cuvanja-reke/

Dolenec, D. (2013). *Democratic institutions and authoritarian rule in Southeast Europe*. ECPR Press.

Đorđević, D. (2020a, December 15). Najmanje svaka peta mala hidroelektrana u Srbiji izgrađena bez uslova zaštite prirode. *Balkan Insight*. https://balkaninsight.com/2020/12/15/zeleni-ideali-prljava-energija-obnovljivi-izvori-podrzani-od-eu-doveli-do-posledica-po-prirodu/?lang=sr

Đorđević, D. (2020b). Green ideals, dirty energy: The EU-backed renewables drive that went wrong. *BIRN*. https://balkaninsight.com/2020/12/15/green-ideals-dirty-energy-the-eu-backed-renewables-drive-that-went-wrong/

Đorđević, D., & Šarić, M. (2019). U Beogradu održan protest protiv kreditiranja MHE. *Centar za istraživačko novinarstvo Srbije*. https://www.cins.rs/u-beogradu-odrzan-protest-protiv-kreditiranja-mhe/

Đukić Pejić, J. (2020, August 16). Struka i motika u odbrani reka Stare planine. *DW*. https://www.dw.com/sr/struka-i-motika-u-odbrani-reka-stare-planine/a-54583872

Đurić, M. (2018, December 25). Incident u selu Rakita, sukob privatnog obezbeđenja i meštana. *N1*. https://rs.n1info.com/vesti/a447042-incident-u-selu-rakita-sukob-privatnog-obezbedjenja-i-mestana/

EBRD. (2018). EPS small hydro power plants – invitation for tenders. https://www.ebrd.com/cs/Satellite?c=Content&cid=1395273688308&d=Mobile&pagename=EBRD%2FContent%2FContentLayout

Energy Community. https://www.energy-community.org/aboutus/whoweare.html

European Parliament. (2009). Better coordination between the European Investment Bank and the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development. *Press Release – Economic and Monetary Affairs*. https://www.europarl.europa.eu/sides/getDoc.do?language=en&type=IM-PRESS&reference=20090325IPR52551

European Water Movement. (2018a). The European Water Movement supports the call for the preservation of the rivers of Stara Planina. http://europeanwater.org/news/press-releases/842-the-european-water-movement-supports-the-call-for-the-preservation-of-the-rivers-of-stara-planina

European Water Movement. (2018b). Protecting rivers from dams and hydropower plants projects. http://europeanwater.org/actions/country-city-focus/848-protecting-rivers-from-dams-and-hydropower-plants-projects

Filipov, L. J. (2018, November 14). Rakita postala centar borbe za očuvanje reka i prirode, svakodnevne straže. *Južne Vesti*. https://www.juznevesti.com/Drushtvo/Rakita-postala-centar-borbe-za-ocuvanje-reka-i-prirode-svakodnevne-straze.sr.html

Franco, J., Mehta, L., & Veldwisch, G. J. (2013). The global politics of water grabbing. *Third World Quarterly*, *34*(9), 1651–1675. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2013.843852

Gallop, P. (2020, January 22). Serbia finally moves to halt unfair advantage for small hydropower plants. *Bankwatch*. https://bankwatch.org/blog/serbia-finally-moves-to-halt-unfair-advantage-for-small-hydropower-plants

Georgievski, J. (2020, August 15). "Oterali smo strah": Kako su borci za reke sa Stare planine postali heroji ekološkog bunta u Srbiji. *BBC News*. https://www.bbc.com/serbian/lat/srbija-53773502

Glas amerike. (2021, April 10). "Ekološki ustanak" u Beogradu: Potreban nam je ekološki patriotizam. *Voice of America*. https://www.glasamerike.net/a/ekoloski-ustanak-protest-beograd-srbija/5848054.html

Gregson, N., & Crang, M. (2017). Illicit economies: Customary illegality, moral economies and circulation. *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers*, *42*(2), 206–219. https://doi.org/10.1111/tran.12158

Gurol, J., Jenss, A., Rodríguez, F., Schuetze, B., & Wetterich, C. (forthcoming). Authoritarian power and contestation beyond the state. *Globalizations*, 1–13.

Harvey, D. (2004). The new imperialism: Accumulation by dispossession. *Socialist Register*, *40*, 63–87.

Insajder. (2019). Nagodba za gradnju male hidroelektrane uprkos zabrani inspekcije: Šest meseci uslovno i 800 evra. https://insajder.net/sr/sajt/tema/15448/

International Energy Agency. (2021). *Hydropower special market report: Analysis and forecast to 2030*. IEA Publications. https://iea.blob.core.windows.net/assets/4d2d4365-08c6-4171-9ea2-8549fabd1c8d/HydropowerSpecialMarketReport_corr.pdf

Janačković, B. (2019, May 8). Izabrali zatvor umesto novčane kazne – aktivisti kažnjeni sa po 20,000 dinara jer su preko Fejsbuka pozvali na čišćenje reke, a nisu prijavili skup. *Blic*. https://www.blic.rs/vesti/drustvo/izabrali-zatvor-umesto-novcane-kazne-aktivisti-kaznjeni-sa-po-20000-dinara-jer-su/rl44g9j

Janković, M. (2022, February 10). Ekološke stranke i pokreti u Srbiji: Zašto je zeleno postalo omiljena boja u srpskoj politici. *BBC News*. https://www.bbc.com/serbian/lat/srbija-60230813

Jones, A., & Clark, J. (2010). *The spatialities of Europeanization: Power, governance and territory in Europe*. Routledge.

Jovanović, S. (2019a, May 22). EBRD tightens environmental, disclosure standards for all hydropower projects. *Balkan Green Energy News*. https://balkangreenenergynews.com/ebrd-tightens-environmental-disclosure-standards-for-all-hydropower-projects/

Jovanović, S. (2019b, July 18). Run-of-river hydropower: Two years on, the struggle continues. *Balkan Green Energy News*. https://balkangreenenergynews.com/run-of-river-hydropower-two-years-on-the-struggle-continues/

Kibler, K. M., & Tullos, D. D. (2013). Cumulative biophysical impact of small and large hydropower development in Nu River, China. *Water Resources Research*, *49*(6), 3104–3118. https://doi.org/10.1002/wrcr.20243

Kostić, V., & Đorđević, D. (2018). Male hidroelektrane: Država i firme povezane sa Vučićevim kumom najviše profitiraju. *CINS*. https://www.cins.rs/male-hidroelektrane-drzava-i-firme-povezane-sa-vucicevim-kumom-najvise-profitiraju/

Liu, D., Liu, H., Wang, X., & Kremere, E. (Eds.). (2019). *World small hydropower development report 2019*. United Nations Industrial Development Organization; International Center on Small Hydro Power. https://www.unido.org/sites/default/files/files/2020-07/Executive%20Summary.pdf

Marinković, L. (2019, May 29). Mini-hidroelektrane u Srbiji: Zašto su borci za opstanak reka spremni da žrtvuju i sopstvenu slobodu. *BBC News na srpskom*. https://www.bbc.com/serbian/lat/srbija-48279097?xtor=AL-73-%5Bpartner%5D-%5Bjuznevesti.com%5D-%5Blink%5D-%5Bserbian%5D-%5Bbizdev%5D-%5Bisapi%5D

N1 Beograd. (2018, November 22). Meštanin Rakite o MHE: Ne čuju nas ni opština, ni država. *N1*. https://rs.n1info.com/biznis/a438011-aleksandar-jovanovic-i-desmir-stojanov-gosti-dana-uzivo/

Nešić, N. (2020, July 22). "Pukle" MHE na teritoriji opštine Pirot, aktivisti kažu – odbranićemo i Rakitu. *N1*. https://rs.n1info.com/vesti/a622394-pukle-mhe-na-teritoriji-opstine-pirot-aktivisti-kazu-odbranicemo-i-rakitu/

Odbranimo reke Stare Planine. (2021). Ubistvo prava: Ubistvo pravde za planinske reke. *Beogradski centar za bezbednosnu politiku*. https://bezbednost.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/Ubistvo-prava-%E2%80%93-ubistvo-pravde-za-planinske-reke.pdf

Odbranimo reke Stare Planine. (2022). About. *Facebook*. https://www.facebook.com/groups/1925328764350247/announcements

Opperman, J. (2018). The unexpectedly large impacts of small hydropower. *Forbes*. https://www.forbes.com/sites/jeffopperman/2018/08/10/the-unexpectedly-large-impacts-of-small-hydropower/

Paish, O. (2002). Small hydro power: Technology and current status. *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews*, *6*(6), 537–556. https://doi.org/10.1016/S1364-0321(02)00006-0

Panić, M., Urošev, M., Milanović Pešić, A., Brankov, J., & Bjeljac, Ž. (2013). Small hydropower plants in Serbia: Hydropower potential, current state and perspectives. *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews*, *23*, 341–349. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.rser.2013.03.016

Petrović, I. (2019, September 21). Dobar biznis za uski krug ljudi, ali štetan za Srbiju. *Deutsche Welle*. https://www.dw.com/sr/dobar-biznis-za-uski-krug-ljudi-ali-%C5%A1tetan-za-srbiju/a-50524666

Piletić, A. (2022). The role of the urban scale in anchoring authoritarian neoliberalism: A look at post-2012 neoliberalization in Belgrade, Serbia. *Globalizations*, *19*(2), 285–300. https://doi.org/10.1080/14747731.2021.1882817

Rajić, J., Pavlović, M., & Popović, M. (2020). Studija slučaja: pravni aspekti slučaja izgradnje male hidroelektrane„Zvonce." *Renewables and Environmental Regulatory Institute*. https://www.reri.org.rs/wp-content/uploads/2020/04/Studija-MHE-Zvonce.pdf

RERI. (2019). Studija slučaja MHE Zvonce – Toliko kršenja propisa i procedura ne može da stane u naslov. *Renewables and Environmental Regulatory Institute, Action SEE*. https://www.reri.org.rs/wp-content/uploads/2019/12/Studija-slu%C4%8Daja-MHE-Zvonce.pdf

Rujević, N. (2022, 25 March). Desnica u Srbiji: Rascepkani i jalovi u Vučićevoj igri. *Deutsche Welle*. https://www.dw.com/sr/desnica-u-srbiji-rascepkani-i-jalovi-u-vu%C4%8Di%C4%87evoj-igri/a-61255661

Sedelmeier, U. (2014). Anchoring democracy from above? The European Union and democratic backsliding in Hungary and Romania after accession. *Journal of Common Market Studies*, *52*(1), 105–121. https://doi.org/10.1111/jcms.12082

Selaković, B., Stevkovski, D., Teofilović, I., Petrović, T., & Grbović, P. (2021). Monitoring matrix on enabling environment for civil society development. Country report: Serbia 2020. https://www.gradjanske.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/01/Monitoring-Matrix-2020-.pdf

Shields, S. (2020). The EBRD, fail forward neoliberalism and the construction of the European periphery. *The Economic and Labor Relations Review*, *31*(2), 230–248. https://doi.org/10.1177/1035304620916652

Simonović, P. (2019, April 5). Savremena 'otkrića': manje vode – više pastrmke. *Danas*. https://www.danas.rs/dijalog/licni-stavovi/savremena-otkrica-manje-vode-vise-pastrmke/

Stojanović, M. (2019, June 17). Ne smiruju se tenzije u Rakiti, novi protest zbog gradnje mini hidroelektrane. *N1*. https://rs.n1info.com/vesti/a492669-ne-smiruju-se-tenzije-u-rakiti-novi-protest-zbog-gradnje-mini-hidroelektrane/

Tansel, C. B. (2017). Authoritarian neoliberalism: Towards a new research agenda. In C. B. Tansel (Ed.), *States of discipline: Authoritarian neoliberalism and the contested reproduction of capitalist order* (pp. 1–28). Rowman & Littlefield.

Tomić, J. (2020). Saradnik premijerkinog brata u poslu sa malim hidroelektranama. *Centar za istraživačko novinarstvo Srbije*. https://www.cins.rs/saradnik-premijerkinog-brata-u-poslu-sa-malim-hidroelektranama/

Vejnović, I., & Gallop, P. (2018). Financing for hydropower in protected areas in Southeast Europe: 2018 update. https://bankwatch.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/03/Financing-hydropower-southeast-Europe-web-2018-update.pdf

Vlajčić, B. (2019). EBRD lends €160 million to UniCredit Bank Serbia. *EBRD*. https://www.ebrd.com/news/2019/ebrd-lends-160-million-to-unicredit-bank-serbia.html

Zelenáková, M., Fijko, R., Constantin Diaconu, D., & Remenáková, I. (2018). Environmental impact of small hydro power plant – a case study. *Environments*, *5*(12), 1–10. https://doi.org/10.3390/environments5010012.

Zhou, S., Zhang, X., & Liu, J. (2009). The trend of small hydropower development in China. *Renewable Energy*, *34*(4), 1078–1083. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.renene.2008.07.003